Activity

Think-Pair-Share

Do you think the American decision not to join the League was a major setback to the organisation?

11.3 The United Nations



Although the League of Nations did not succeed in its objectives, it however, ignited the dream for a universal Organisation that would work to preserve peace in the world. With the end of the Second World War which witnessed around 72 million casualties, the idea of the United Nations was born. World leaders who had collaborated to bring the war to an end felt a strong need for a mechanism that would ensure lasting peace and prevent future wars. It was also felt that this was possible only through a global Organisation where all nations would work together.

The name 'United Nations' was coined by the then United States President Franklin D. Roosevelt and was first officially used in 1942 when representatives from twenty six nations signed the Declaration by United Nations to continue to fight together against the axis powers in order to obtain just peace. Thus unlike the League of Nations, it began as an alliance that came into being soon after the United States' entry into the war following the attack on Pearl Harbour by Japan and Germany's declaration of war against the United States in December 1941. In August 1944, delegates from China, Soviet Union, United Kingdom and the United States, met in Dumbarton Oaks to draw the basic blueprint for the new International Organisation and by October the outline of the United Nations Charter was ready.

Four main purposes of the United Nations

- Military security
- Economic and social progress
- Upholding of human rights
- International justice.

Following the surrender of Germany in the year 1945, representatives from fifty countries met in San Francisco on June 26, 1945 and signed the Charter. With the conclusion of the Pacific war in October 24, 1945, the United Nations officially came into existence. While making the UN Charter, the drafters faced the same issue that the League of Nations faced which was to lay the foundation of an international organisation that would guarantee peace.

The basic dilemma remained unchanged – how to balance national sovereignty and international idealism? How could one draft a Charter that would effectively deal with the fact that some countries were more equal than others? How could one make sure that one

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